MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 3 — Unit 3: Jasmine and Mistress

INDIAN WRITING IN ENGLISH • M21EG04DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Jasmine and Mistress investigate identity through movement, desire, memory, and the unequal conditions within which people try to choose a life.

Start with a picture

Changing a name can open a possibility without erasing the past. Learning to perform a role can reveal feelings without making them simple. The two novels explore these difficulties through very different narrative worlds.

1. Bharati Mukherjee: Jasmine

Jyoti’s marriage to Prakash, his death, and the meanings attached to his ambitions are important to her later journey. The protagonist’s life crosses Punjab and the United States through marriage, bereavement, migration, exploitation, work, and intimate relationships. Names such as Jyoti, Jasmine, Jase, and Jane mark different social situations and imagined selves.

These names do not produce a perfectly smooth staircase towards freedom. Survival involves vulnerability, unequal power, and difficult departures. The past remains active even when the protagonist refuses a fixed identity.

Narrative movement

The story shifts between moments and places instead of simply reporting a chronological journey. This arrangement lets one version of the self speak through the memory of another. Narration becomes part of reinvention.

How to read migration

Ask what opportunity a new place offers, what it demands, and who can control the conditions of entry. Avoid a simplistic India-as-prison versus America-as-freedom argument. Gender and economic dependence can take new forms after a border crossing.

2. Anita Nair: Mistress

The Kerala setting connects a resort, family relationships, artistic practice, and remembered histories. Radha and her husband Shyam encounter the visitor Chris, whose interest in the Kathakali artist Koman opens further stories. Radha’s desire and dissatisfaction intersect with the memories Koman recounts.

Kathakali and narrative form

The novel uses the navarasas, the nine aesthetic modes or sentiments, as an organising resource. They include love, laughter, compassion or pathos, fury, courage, fear, disgust, wonder, and tranquillity.

These are not identical to nine simple medical or private emotional states. Their aesthetic history matters. In particular, hasya should not be reduced to contempt, nor shanta to the general word freedom.

Desire and possession

Characters want to understand, love, claim, or escape one another. Such desires do not automatically confer a right to control another person. Multiple stories expose the limits of any single explanation of a relationship.

Koman’s account of family history complicates the present. Art is not merely a beautiful background; it shapes how experience is narrated and interpreted.

3. Compare the novels

Mukherjee connects self-making with migration and repeated naming. Nair connects it with art, memory, and intersecting perspectives. Both show that identity is made through choices inside constraints rather than outside all social relationships.

Quick check

1. Does a new name erase Jasmine’s past? **No.**
2. Is Kathakali incidental scenery in Mistress? **No; it helps organise the narrative.**
3. Does desire justify possession? **No; the novels invite scrutiny of that assumption.**

Build an exam answer

1. Define identity as an ongoing relation rather than a label.
2. Explain names and narrative time in Jasmine.
3. Qualify the promise of migration.
4. Analyse Kathakali and competing stories in Mistress.
5. Compare choice, dependence, and the limits of knowledge.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not call migration an automatic liberation or translate the navarasas into oversimplified emotional labels without explanation.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Discuss how narrative form shapes the representation of identity in Jasmine and Mistress.

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

In Jasmine, identity is made visible through movement among names, locations, and relationships. A chronological summary could describe successive experiences, but the novel's shifting arrangement makes their continuing interaction more important. The speaking self does not stand beyond the past; it reworks the past in the process of narrating.

Migration consequently becomes more than arrival in a new country. It opens choices while exposing the protagonist to new dependencies and forms of violence. A strong reading preserves both agency and vulnerability instead of treating reinvention as a simple success formula.

Mistress uses a different formal resource. Kathakali's aesthetic vocabulary and the interaction of remembered stories connect artistic performance with the interpretation of desire. Radha, Shyam, Chris, and Koman do not provide one transparent explanation of their relations. Their differences make possession and understanding difficult to separate.

The novels can therefore be compared through the way form resists a fixed identity. One emphasises repeated naming and temporal movement, the other aesthetic organisation and intersecting histories. The comparison is strongest when a formal choice is connected with a specific social pressure rather than discussed as decoration.

Use the discussion well

Answer the exact question, not every possible topic. Make one clear point per paragraph, support it with a textual detail or a relevant classroom example, and explain its significance. Check exact quotations against the assigned text. The discussion is paraphrase and guidance, not a quotation or a guaranteed exam answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

The following numbered prompts are retained from the unit for revision. Obvious source errors are discussed in the coverage review; a prompt's assumptions should not be accepted automatically. These are not predictions or complete written assignments.

1. Explain Jasmine's transformation.
2. Explain the relationship between Jasmine and Prakash.
3. Explain the non-linear narrative of Jasmine.
4. Analyse Jasmine as a post-colonial novel.
5. Explain the rebirth of Jasmine.
6. Explain the use of the navarasas in the novel.
7. Explain the marital relationships and failures in the novel.
8. Sketch the character of Shyam.
9. Delineate the features of Indian English Fiction.